IELTS Speaking Band Descriptors

A. Fluency and Coherence

Term	Meaning
Fluency	How smooth and continuous their speech is — without too much pausing, hesitating, or restarting.
Coherence	How well their ideas are organised and linked — do their sentences and thoughts flow logically and clearly?

*Key Indicators of **Fluency***

Speech rate

- Not too fast (which causes errors or slurring) and not too slow (which affects listener focus).
- Measured by how many words per minute **with meaning** are said (not just fillers).
- **Why it matters**: If they speak too slowly, the listener forgets what was just said. If they're too fast, it sounds rushed and unclear.

Example:

> ✗ *"Uhh... I... think... maybe... yes... because it's... uhh... hot."*
>
> ✓ *"Yes, I think summer is better because the weather is warm and there are more things to do outside."*

Speech continuity

- Is the speech **interrupted a lot** by:
  - false starts? (e.g. "*I go— I mean, I went to...*")
  - backtracking? (changing what they said mid-sentence)
  - unnecessary repetition? (e.g. "*I like, I like, I like movies*")
  - long pauses while searching for words?

Fluency is not about speed alone. A fluent speaker can speak naturally without stopping too often or repeating themselves.

Example of a problem:

> ✗ *"I uhh... I think... it's... good. Because... umm... people... people can... can..."*

Better version:

> ✓ *"I think it's a good idea because people have more time to relax."*

*Key Indicators of **Coherence***

Logical sequencing of spoken sentences

- The listener should be able to **follow the speaker's train of thought** without confusion.
- Spoken sentences (even if casual or incomplete) should still build upon each other logically.

Example:

> ✓ *"I usually get up early. After that, I go jogging for about 30 minutes. Then I take a shower and eat breakfast."*
>
> ✗ *"I get up. I breakfast. Shower. Um… jogging… no… jogging later."*

Clear marking of stages in a discussion

- Use signposts or transitions in speech, like:
  - *"Firstly…", "On the other hand…", "In my opinion…"*
- Proper **pauses and intonation** signal that one idea is done and another is starting.

Example:

> ✓ *"To start with, I'll talk about the advantages. Then I'll explain why I still think it's not perfect."*

Relevance of spoken sentences

- All parts of their answer should stay **on topic** and move the answer forward.
- Avoid rambling or jumping around topics without a clear purpose.

Example of poor coherence:

> ✗ *"So I like traveling. I also have a dog. My dog is big. Traveling is good."*

Better version:

> ✓ *"I like traveling because it helps me learn about new cultures. One time, I even took my dog on a trip to the mountains."*

Use of cohesive devices

These are the **words and phrases that link ideas**, such as:

- Logical connectors: *because, although, since, so*
- Pronouns: *this, that, it, they*
- Conjunctions: *and, but, or, then*
- Referencing tools: *the former, the latter, in contrast, for example*

Example:

> ✓ *"I enjoy sports like basketball and tennis. These activities help me stay fit. Also, I often play them with friends, which makes them more fun."*

Spoken Sentence

The IELTS uses the term "**spoken sentence**" to describe a unit of speech that **functions like a sentence**, even if it's not grammatically perfect.

It:

- Has one clear idea,
- Often has a pause and falling pitch at the end,
- Can be informal, fragmented, or missing written elements.

Examples of spoken sentences:

✓ *"Yeah, totally agree." (no subject-verb-object but still clear and complete in context)*

✓ *"Couldn't believe it!" (short, verbless, but understandable and meaningful)*

So even if it's not a "perfect" sentence, it can still be **coherent** and count toward the score.

JIC Scoresheet

Fluency

Hesitation

Quantifying

What it is	Pauses, especially unnatural or frequent ones, when thinking of words or grammar. *e.g., "Uhhh… I think… uhhh maybe…"*
How to check	Count unnatural hesitations—not natural thinking pauses. Mark frequent hesitation down. *Hesitations for idea generation are more forgivable than hesitation for word recall.*

False Start

Quantifying and Qualifying

What it is	When the speaker begins to say something, stops, and then rephrases. ➤ *Correct Example*: "I think the most important—no, actually, the first thing I want to say is…" ➤ This is **NOT** starting with "Because…" That's a **discourse marker**, not a false start.
How to check	Note if the student starts, stops, and rewords awkwardly or fluidly. Frequent, clumsy false starts lower fluency.

Intrusive Filler

Quantifying

What it is	Overuse of fillers like *"like," "you know," "uhm," "so yeah."* These **don't add content**.
How to check	Note every time they use empty fillers. Penalize only when they dominate the response.

Self-corrections

Quantifying and Qualifying

What it is	The student corrects themselves mid-sentence. ➤ *Example*: "She go—she **goes** to school every day."
How to check	If rare and natural = good; frequent and disruptive = lower fluency. Also check if grammar improves after correction.

Willing to respond to questions

Qualifying

What it is	The student answers promptly, even if not perfectly. Not pausing excessively or refusing to respond.
How to check	Do they stall or engage right away? Short responses may indicate nervousness or language limitation.

Coherence

Understanding of questions

Qualifying

What it is	The ability to grasp what is being asked.
How to check	Note if they ask to repeat a lot, or respond off-topic. Repeating questions may show comprehension difficulty.

Accuracy of answer

Qualifying

What it is	Does the response **match the question** logically and grammatically?
How to check	If the student consistently answers the wrong type of question, mark lower.

Organisation of ideas

Qualifying

What it is	Logical flow—using sequencing words or transitions to structure their thoughts. ➤ *Example*: "First of all… Then… Finally…"
How to check	Are there clear transitions? Does the answer build logically? Or are thoughts all over the place?

Complex and detailed responses

Qualifying

What it is	Extended answers that go beyond yes/no. Including **examples, reasons, or elaboration**.
How to check	Are the responses only 1-2 sentences? Do they give details, or just generic answers?

Topic development

Qualifying

What it is	The student can expand or sustain the conversation around a theme, not just answer questions but show **depth of ideas**.
How to check	Look for expansion (e.g., giving opinions, examples, contrast, or consequences). Do they show progression?

Band Scores Explained

Fluency and Coherence

Band 1

- *Essentially none.*
- *Speech is totally incoherent.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Essentially none**
  - means the student **does not produce any real language**
  - or if they try to speak, it's so minimal or broken that we can't understand anything.
- **Totally incoherent**
  - means **there's no logical or understandable structure at all**
  - The examiner cannot follow what the student is trying to say.
  - Even individual words may not connect meaningfully.

This is one step above a Band 0 (which is when the student says nothing at all or just produces memorised material that's off-topic).

What might this sound like?

The candidate might:

- Just say random, unrelated words:
  - *"Uhh... fish... um... school... okay..."*
- Repeat the question in confusion or mumble.
- Pause for long periods, unable to continue.
- Speak in a way that's impossible to follow (e.g., wrong syllables, missing vowels, or sounds that don't resemble English words).

For example:

> *Examiner: "Do you work or are you a student?"*
>
> *Candidate: "Uhh... you... you do... yes... student... me... yes okay..."*

Here, the examiner can't make any sense of what is being said — that's **Band 1**.

Band 2

- *Lengthy pauses before nearly every word.*
- *Isolated words may be recognisable but speech is of virtually no communicative significance.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

Let's simplify each bullet:

- **Lengthy pauses before nearly every word**
  - The student stops for a long time before almost every single word.
  - It's not just hesitation — it's a sign that they are mentally translating, unsure about what to say, or don't know enough English to form a sentence.
- **Isolated words may be recognisable...**
  - The student can say a few words that you recognize, like "school," "coffee," or "go," but not in full sentences
- **...but speech is of virtually no communicative significance.**
  - There is almost no meaningful communication.

- Even though the student tries to say something, we can't understand what they're trying to express overall.

What might this sound like?

Here's an example:

> *Examiner: "Do you work or are you a student?"*
>
> *Candidate*:
>
> *"...uh... me... uh... student... uh... go... school... uh... study... uh... book."*

There are:

- Long pauses between each word
- Disconnected, unclear ideas
- No full thought or complete answer

Even if the **words are correct**, the **message is unclear**, making it hard to follow or respond to as a conversation.

Band 3

- *Frequent, sometimes long, pauses occur while candidate searches for words.*
- *Limited ability to link simple sentences and go beyond simple responses to questions.*
- *Frequently unable to convey basic message.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Frequent, sometimes long, pauses occur while candidate searches for words.**
  - The student knows some English, but they stop often to think or remember vocabulary.
  - Pauses interrupt the natural flow of speech.
  - These pauses are **not just nervous hesitation**—they show a **real struggle to find words or form sentences**.

  Example:

  "I... uh... go... um... yesterday... uh... with my... friend... to... uh... the... uh... mall."

- **Limited ability to link simple sentences and go beyond simple responses to questions.**
  - The student can **answer simple questions** but **rarely expands** beyond that.
  - They may speak in **short, choppy sentences**:
    - *"I like cats. They are cute. I have one."*
  - **Linking words** like *and, but,* or *because* are **rare** or **used incorrectly**.
- **Frequently unable to convey basic message.**
  - Even though the student is trying to speak, their ideas **don't come across clearly**.
  - The listener often has to **guess the meaning**.
  - Grammar, vocabulary gaps, or word order issues **hide the message**.

  Think: The message might *be there, but it's buried under* ***broken structure and lots of pauses.***

What might this sound like?

> *Examiner: "Tell me about your hometown."*
>
> *Candidate*:
>
> *"Uh... my... city... is... big... uh... many... car... people... um... go... job... uh... traffic..."*

You can hear some key words, and they're on topic, but:

- Sentences aren't connected.
- Ideas are vague and unclear.
- Pauses break the rhythm.
- The listener struggles to understand.

Band 4

- *Unable to keep going without noticeable pauses.*
- *Speech may be slow with frequent repetition.*
- *Often self-corrects.*
- *Can link simple sentences but often with repetitious use of connectives.*
- *Some breakdowns in coherence.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Unable to keep going without noticeable pauses**
  - The student **tries to speak**, but they **keep stopping** — the pauses are obvious and disrupt the flow.
  - These pauses happen because they're **thinking hard**, struggling with vocabulary or grammar, or unsure how to continue.
  - They **can't maintain momentum** in a conversation.

  Example:

  "I… um… live in… a… city… uh… big… uh… traffic… problem…"

- **Speech may be slow with frequent repetition**
  - They repeat the same **words** or **phrases** over and over, sometimes to buy time, sometimes because they **don't know another way** to say something.
  - The **pace is noticeably slow**, often unnatural.

  Example:

  "My house is… big… big house… I… I like big house… because… it's big…"

- **Often self-corrects**
  - They **notice** their own mistakes and try to fix them, but:
    - This **slows them down**.
    - It often makes the speech more disjointed.
  - **Self-correction** is a positive sign (they're thinking!), but in Band 4, it's **frequent enough to affect fluency**.

  Example:

  "Yesterday I go—uh, I went to the—uh, I went shopping."

- **Can link simple sentences but often with repetitious use of connectives**
  - They use basic words like "and," "but," or "because" to connect ideas, but they overuse them or use them incorrectly.
  - Complex ideas don't develop naturally — sentences are still basic and repetitive.

  Example:

  "I like pizza because it is good and I eat pizza and my family like pizza and…"

- **Some breakdowns in coherence**
  - The listener can follow some of it, but parts of the message are confusing or don't connect well.
  - Thoughts may be jumbled, off-topic, or incomplete.

  *Think: There's a general message, but the **organisation is messy**, and listeners sometimes **lose track**.*

What might this sound like?

Examiner: "What do you do on the weekend?"

Candidate:

"Uh… weekend… I go to… I go… uh… shopping… and uh… and I eat food and… uh… I… my friends go too… and… uh… I buy, I buy clothes. Because… um… because I like clothes."

Understandable, but:

- Repetitive
- Broken
- Slow
- Disjointed

Band 5

- *Usually able to keep going, but relies on repetition and self-correction to do so and/or on slow speech.*
- *Hesitations are often associated with mid-sentence searches for fairly basic lexis and grammar.*
- *Overuse of certain discourse markers, connectives and other cohesive features.*
- *More complex speech usually causes disfluency but simpler language may be produced fluently.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Usually able to keep going, but relies on repetition and self-correction to do so and/or on slow speech**
  - The student can **speak continuously**, but it doesn't always sound smooth.
  - They **repeat words** or **fix mistakes mid-sentence** to buy time or keep speaking.
  - They **might speak slowly** to stay in control and avoid mistakes.

  Example:

  "I went… uh… I go—no—I went to the store and, um, and I bought, I bought… clothes. Yes."

  *They're trying hard to be clear but their delivery is **slow, repetitive, or disrupted by corrections**.*

- **Hesitations are often associated with mid-sentence searches for fairly basic lexis and grammar**
  - The student **pauses in the middle of sentences** to look for **simple vocabulary or grammar**.
  - These aren't pauses for *difficult* ideas — they're struggling with common words or **basic verb tenses**.

  Example:

  "I… uh… go to the… um… how do you say… uh… supermarket."

  *These hesitations show that they still **haven't mastered everyday structures.***

- **Overuse of certain discourse markers, connectives and other cohesive features**
  - They link ideas together but use the same linking word over and over.
    - Example: *too much "and," "so," or "because."*
  - It sounds unnatural or too mechanical.

  Example:

  "So, I went to school. And then I studied. And then I ate lunch. And then I went home."

  *There's some structure but it's **repetitive and predictable**, showing limited range.*

- **More complex speech usually causes disfluency but simpler language may be produced fluently**
  - The student speaks well when using **basic sentence patterns**.
  - As soon as they try to use **longer or more detailed sentences**, they **struggle** — with pauses, confusion, or errors.

  Example:

"I like… uh… the movie… because… it's… um… interesting.
The story is… uh… how to say… difficult to understand but… I… uh… I liked."

Simple thoughts? Fluent. More complex thoughts? Disfluent.

What might this sound like?

Examiner: "Do you enjoy shopping?"
Candidate:
"Yes, I enjoy shopping. I go shopping every weekend and, uh, I buy clothes and… uh… shoes. And… because… uh… I like fashion. Uh… it's… relaxing… shopping is relaxing for me."

You hear:

- Basic fluency
- Overuse of "and," "uh"
- Hesitation with longer phrases
- Overall message gets across, but not confidently

Band 6

- *Able to keep going and demonstrates a willingness to produce long turns.*
- *Coherence may be lost at times as a result of hesitation, repetition and/or self-correction.*
- *Uses a range of spoken discourse markers, connectives and cohesive features though not always appropriately.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Able to keep going and demonstrates a willingness to produce long turns**
  - The student **can talk at length** without the examiner needing to push too much.
  - "Long turns" = **extended speaking** (especially in Parts 2 and 3).
  - They **don't give one-word or one-sentence answers** — they **try to elaborate**.
  - Even if they make mistakes, they **show effort** to develop their ideas.

  Example:

  "My favorite holiday was when I went to Japan with my friends. We visited Tokyo and Kyoto. In Tokyo, we went to many places like temples and shopping centers. It was very exciting."

  Shows willingness to speak in full ideas and doesn't need to be prompted constantly

- **Coherence may be lost at times as a result of hesitation, repetition and/or self-correction**
  - The student **generally makes sense**, but:
    - Pauses too long
    - Repeats parts of their answer
    - Makes and corrects mistakes that **break the flow**
  - Their ideas **sometimes get a little messy or disconnected**, even though they're understandable overall.

  Example:

  "I… uh… I think… I think that traveling is good because… uh… we can learn, we can learn about different… um… people, I mean cultures."

  Meaning is clear but slight stumbles disrupt smoothness

- **Uses a range of spoken discourse markers, connectives and cohesive features though not always appropriately**
  - The student tries to **organize ideas** using linking phrases like:
    - *However, actually, so, because, first of all, in my opinion*

- However, they **sometimes misuse them** or **sound unnatural**:
  - Using formal phrases in informal contexts
  - Using *however* when *but* fits better
  - Repeating the same one awkwardly

Example:

"Actually, I like swimming. And actually, my brother… uh… he swims too. Because actually it's fun."

*They are trying to **build cohesion** but **overuse or incorrect use** makes it less effective*

What might this sound like?

Examiner: "Do you enjoy shopping?"

Student:

"Yes, I enjoy shopping, especially when I need something. For example, last week I went to buy a gift for my friend's birthday. Uh… it was hard to choose but finally I bought a nice bag. Actually, I don't go shopping very often, but I enjoy it when I do."

You hear:

- Ideas are **developed**
- Attempt at **discourse markers**
- Slight **hesitation**, **repetition**, and one awkward use of *actually*

Band 7

- *Able to keep going and readily produce long turns without noticeable effort.*
- *Some hesitation, repetition and/or self-correction may occur, often mid-sentence and indicate problems with accessing appropriate language. However, these will not affect coherence.*
- *Flexible use of spoken discourse markers, connectives and cohesive features.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Able to keep going and readily produce long turns without noticeable effort**
  - The student speaks **naturally and continuously** — even for **long answers**.
  - **No awkward silence** or excessive "um… uh…" to buy time.
  - The examiner doesn't need to push them to speak more — they **volunteer extra details and examples** confidently.

  Example:

  "Personally, I really enjoy spending time outdoors. I often go hiking with friends on the weekend, especially if the weather is good. It's a great way to relax, get some exercise, and appreciate nature."

  *They sound **comfortable and spontaneous**.*

- **Some hesitation, repetition and/or self-correction may occur, often mid-sentence and indicate problems with accessing appropriate language. However, these will not affect coherence.**
  - Minor **pauses**, **restarts**, or **word searching** can still happen — that's normal.
  - These issues are usually **due to vocabulary retrieval** (e.g., searching for the right word).
  - **The meaning is still clear**, and the answer flows logically.

  Example:

  "I think it's… um… it's essential to—what's the word—ah, to maintain a balance between work and rest."

*You can still follow their ideas. Their **logic and progression are intact**. Some **mid-sentence struggle**, but not disruptive.*

- **Flexible use of spoken discourse markers, connectives and cohesive features**
  - The speaker uses a **variety** of linking devices naturally and appropriately.
  - They don't repeat the same words like *and*, *so*, or *because*.
  - They may use:
    - *On the other hand…*
    - *In contrast…*
    - *Actually…*
    - *That being said…*
    - *For instance…*
  - These linkers **fit the context and tone** and enhance clarity.

Example:

"I usually prefer studying in the evening because I find I concentrate better then. That being said, I try not to stay up too late, since I have early classes."

Smooth, varied, and contextual use of cohesive language.

What might this sound like?

Examiner: "Do you enjoy shopping?"
Student:
"I don't really enjoy shopping for clothes, to be honest. I find it a bit tedious. On the other hand, I love going to bookstores. I could spend hours browsing through titles, especially if they're related to history or travel."

You hear:

- Extended, natural answer
- Logical progression of thought
- Range of connectors used appropriately
- Maybe a hesitation or two — but it doesn't affect understanding

Band 8

- *Fluent with only very occasional repetition or self-correction.*
- *Hesitation may occasionally be used to find words or grammar, but most will be content related.*
- *Topic development is coherent, appropriate and relevant.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Fluent with only very occasional repetition or self-correction**
  - The candidate speaks almost **effortlessly** and **naturally**.
  - There is **very little stopping**, **repeating**, or **fixing** their own words.
  - If self-correction happens, it's **minor and fast**, not disruptive.

Example:

"I visited Italy last year and—oh, I mean two years ago now—it was one of the best trips I've taken."

*Self-correction is accurate and **doesn't break flow**. The speaker sounds confident and controlled.*

- **Hesitation may occasionally be used to find words or grammar, but most will be content related**
  - The candidate **very rarely hesitates**, and when they do:
    - It's because they're **choosing the right idea**, not because they lack vocabulary or grammar.
    - These pauses are part of **normal thinking** during complex responses.

Example:

"I think one of the biggest challenges in education today is… hmm… probably the unequal access to quality learning materials."

*Hesitation is due to **thinking about content**, not **language struggle**.*

- **Topic development is coherent, appropriate and relevant**
  - Their answers are:
    - **Well-organized**
    - **Connected to the question**
    - **Developed with clear, relevant examples or reasons**
  - The listener can **easily follow their train of thought** from start to end.

Example:

"Personally, I believe that cities should invest more in public transport. Not only does it reduce traffic congestion, but it also lowers carbon emissions. For example, in my city, the government introduced a new train line and it's significantly decreased the number of cars on the road."

*Ideas follow a **logical structure**. Everything is **on-topic** and **clearly expressed**.*

What might this sound like?

Examiner: "Do you think young people spend too much time on their phones?"
Student:
"Yes, I do think so, to an extent. Many young people rely on their phones for communication and entertainment, which isn't necessarily bad. However, I believe it becomes problematic when it replaces real-life interaction. I've noticed that some of my younger cousins, for instance, struggle to hold a conversation without checking their phones every few minutes."

You hear:

- Very fluent
- Relevant and detailed example
- Hesitation is only natural — not disruptive
- No overused connectors or awkward phrasing

Band 9

- *Fluent with only very occasional repetition or self-correction.*
- *Any hesitation that occurs is used only to prepare the content of the next utterance and not to find words or grammar.*
- *Speech is situationally appropriate and cohesive features are fully acceptable.*
- *Topic development is fully coherent and appropriately extended.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Fluent with only very occasional repetition or self-correction**
  - The speaker talks with **total ease**.
  - They almost **never repeat** themselves or **go back to fix** what they said.
  - If repetition or correction happens, it is so minor that it feels **natural**, not distracting.

Example:

"The first reason I enjoy traveling is—well, I suppose it's the exposure to different cultures, really."

*Smooth flow. The self-correction doesn't break fluency. Repetition sounds like **native-like adjustment**.*

- **Any hesitation that occurs is used only to prepare the content of the next utterance and not to find words or grammar**
  - Hesitations are **intentional and thoughtful**.
  - The candidate is not pausing because they **lack vocabulary or grammar knowledge**.
  - They pause to **choose the best example or organize their ideas**.

  Example:

  "I think… the most pressing issue for urban planners today is probably the increasing demand for sustainable infrastructure."

  *Pause before "the most pressing issue" is a **thinking pause**, not a language struggle. Hesitation **adds clarity**, not confusion.*

- **Speech is situationally appropriate and cohesive features are fully acceptable**
  - The candidate uses **formal/informal language** correctly depending on the topic.
  - They **naturally weave in cohesive devices** (like connectors, linkers, transitions) that **suit the tone** and **register**.
  - No overuse, no unnatural sounding phrases.

  Example:

  "Actually, I'd argue that while online education offers flexibility, it often lacks the interactive dynamics of traditional classrooms. That being said, with the right tools, it can still be highly effective."

  Proper academic-style phrasing for a serious topic. Varied cohesive devices: actually, that being said.

- **Topic development is fully coherent and appropriately extended**
  - Ideas are **clearly structured**, **progress logically**, and are **fully developed**.
  - The speaker provides **depth**—not just one reason or opinion, but elaboration with examples, causes, consequences, comparisons, etc.

  Example:

  "I believe that books still hold significant value despite the rise of digital media. For one, they offer a distraction-free reading experience. Also, many people find the physical sensation of turning pages comforting. In fact, studies suggest that we retain more information when reading from paper compared to screens."

  *Organized reasoning. Extended with examples and references. Everything is **relevant** and **easy to follow***

What might this sound like?

Examiner: "Do you think the media influences the way people think?"
Student:
"Absolutely, the media plays a powerful role in shaping public perception. Take news outlets, for instance—how a story is framed can drastically alter how viewers interpret it. Moreover, social media platforms often amplify extreme opinions, which can distort reality for users who aren't critically engaged."

You hear:

- No filler words like *uh… um…*
- Clear idea organization
- Sophisticated yet natural vocabulary and transitions
- **Zero evidence** of vocabulary search or grammatical confusion

B. Lexical Resource

"Lexical Resource" refers to how **well the speaker uses vocabulary** — not just whether they use big words, but whether their word choices:

- Suit the situation and the topic,
- Are varied enough,
- Are accurate and natural,
- Help the speaker explain things **clearly**, even when they don't know the exact word.

*Key Indicators of **Lexical Resource***

Variety of words used

- Does the test taker avoid repeating the same words again and again?
- Do they show they know **synonyms** or **topic-related vocabulary?**

Example:

✗ *"The food was good. I liked the food. The food was nice."* (very basic and repetitive)

✓ *"The food was delicious. I especially liked the pasta, which was cooked perfectly."*

Adequacy and appropriacy of vocabulary

- Does the vocabulary **fit the situation or topic**?

  a) **Referential meaning**

  This refers to the test taker's **ability to use the correct word for a thing or idea** — like labeling concepts or objects.

  Example:

  ✗ *"The flying thing you ride to another country."* → *instead of "plane"*

  ✓ *"I took a flight from Manila to Tokyo last year."*

  b) **Style (formal/informal)**

  Can the speaker **adapt** their word choice depending on the topic or situation?

  Example:

  ✓ *"I'm keen on trying new cuisines."* → suitable for IELTS

  ✗ *"I'm hella into food."* → too informal for the test

  c) **Collocation** (including idiomatic expressions)

  This refers to how well the test taker:

  - **Puts words together in natural combinations** (collocations)
  - Uses **idioms or expressions** common in English

Examples of natural collocations:

✓ *"make a decision" (not 'do a decision')*

✓ *"strong coffee" (not 'hard coffee')*

Examples of idiomatic usage:

✓ *"I hit the books before the exam."*

✗ *"I touch the books before exam."*

d) **Indicating attitude through word choice**

This means using vocabulary to express **opinions and feelings** clearly — even subtly.

Example:

✓ *"That law is quite controversial."* → expresses disapproval carefully

✓ *"I'm absolutely thrilled about the opportunity."* → strong positive attitude

✗ *"I think it's good."* → vague; lacks nuance

Ability to use paraphrase

- Can the student **explain an idea in other words** when they forget or don't know the exact term?

  Example:

  ✓ *"I forgot the word, but it's like a big hospital for animals… an animal clinic."*

  ✓ *"It's a tool you use to open cans — like scissors, but stronger. Oh, a can opener!"*

JIC Scoresheet

Lexical Resource

Use of Simple Vocabulary

Qualifying

What it is	Using only **basic** or **high-frequency words**, like “good,” “bad,” “nice,” “thing,” instead of more descriptive or precise terms.
How to check	Ask yourself: Did the student go beyond textbook words? Or did they rely on simple or vague ones?

Dependence on Question

Qualifying

What it is	The student simply **repeats the question’s vocabulary** in their answer without rephrasing. ➤ *Example*: Q: "What’s your favorite hobby?" A: "My favorite hobby is reading." (Better: "I love getting lost in novels when I have free time.")
How to check	Do they mirror question phrases? Can they reword or explain differently?

Repetitive Extensions

Qualifying and Quantifying

What it is	When students repeat the same word or phrase within a response due to **limited vocabulary**. ➤ *Example*: “It’s a big city with a big park and a big mall.”
How to check	Count repeated words. See if they try to use alternatives like “huge,” “spacious,” “massive,” etc.

Appropriacy and Precision

Qualifying

What it is	Using the **right word** for the right context and **expressing exact meaning**. ➤ “I **attended** a concert” is more precise than “I **went to** a concert.”
How to check	Listen for vague word use ("thing," "stuff," "nice") or incorrect collocations. Misusing words lowers the score.

Use of Connectives and Markers

Qualifying

What it is	Using linking words and phrases to **logically connect ideas**. ➤ Examples: *because, however, although, in contrast, on top of that*
How to check	Do they use only “and… and… and…”? Or do they attempt varied transitions?

Band Scores Explained

Lexical Resource

Band 1

- *No resource bar a few isolated words.*
- *No communication possible.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **No resource bar a few isolated words**
  - The candidate knows only a **very small number** of **basic**, often **unrelated** English words.
  - They may say:
    - Personal information (e.g., "name," "Philippines")
    - Very common nouns or verbs (e.g., "eat," "cat," "go")
  - They cannot **combine** words into phrases or sentences.
  - They have **no control over meaning or context**.
  - means the student **does not produce any real language**
  - or if they try to speak, it's so minimal or broken that we can't understand anything.

  Example:

  Examiner: "What do you do in your free time?"

  Candidate: "Uh… music… eat… movie."

  No sentence structure; words are isolated and random; listener cannot understand a clear idea

- **No communication possible**
  - The listener cannot understand what the speaker is trying to say.
  - There is **no meaningful message** being communicated.
  - Even if the student says some words, they don't form a coherent thought.

  Example:

  Uh… play… home… no school… uh… uh…

  No logical idea; examiner cannot interact or ask follow-up questions

What might this sound like?

- *Words are in English*
- *No sentence structure*
- *No communicative meaning*

For example:

Examiner: "Can you tell me about your hometown?"

Candidate: "City… big… car… umm… nice."

Examiner: "Do you like going to the cinema?"

Candidate: "Cinema… good… uh… popcorn…"

Band 2

- *Very limited resource.*

- *Utterances consist of isolated words or memorised utterances.*
- *Little communication possible without the support of mime or gesture.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **No resource bar a few isolated words**
  - The candidate knows only a **very small number** of **basic**, often **unrelated** English words.
  - They may say:
    - Personal information (e.g., "name," "Philippines")
    - Very common nouns or verbs (e.g., "eat," "cat," "go")
  - They cannot **combine** words into phrases or sentences.
  - They have **no control over meaning or context**.
  - means the student **does not produce any real language**
  - or if they try to speak, it's so minimal or broken that we can't understand anything.

  Example:

  Examiner: "What do you do in your free time?"

  Candidate: "Uh… music… eat… movie."

  No sentence structure; words are isolated and random; listener cannot understand a clear idea

- **No communication possible**
  - The listener cannot understand what the speaker is trying to say.
  - There is **no meaningful message** being communicated.
  - Even if the student says some words, they don't form a coherent thought.

  Example:

  Uh… play… home… no school… uh… uh…

  No logical idea; examiner cannot interact or ask follow-up questions

What might this sound like?

- *Some phrases understood*
- *Doesn't fully answer the question*
- *Communicative value is low*

For example:

Examiner: "Do you work or are you a student?"

Candidate:

"Uh… I am student. School. Morning. Bus. Teacher. Good."

Band 3

- *Resource limited to simple vocabulary used primarily to convey personal information.*
- *Vocabulary inadequate for unfamiliar topics.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Resource limited to simple vocabulary used primarily to convey personal information**
  - The candidate can:
    - Talk about **themselves**, their **home**, their **daily routine**, and **likes/dislikes**.
    - Use **very simple words** like "family", "school", "food", "happy", "city", "music", etc.
  - Vocabulary is **repetitive** and **often inaccurate** outside their comfort zone.

Example:

My name is Anna. I live in Vietnam. I like music. My family is small. I go to school every day.

Understandable; answers personal questions; limited range; cannot express deeper ideas

- **Vocabulary inadequate for unfamiliar topics**
  - The candidate **gets lost** or **breaks down** when asked about:
    - Abstract topics (e.g., the environment, technology, education systems)
    - Opinions that require explanation
    - Describing sequences of events or comparisons
  - They might:
    - Repeat the same simple words ("good," "nice," "bad," "big")
    - Fall silent or change the topic
    - Use incorrect words because of vocabulary gaps

Example:

Examiner: "What do you think are the advantages of public transport?"
Candidate: "Uh… good… bus… um… I no car… easy go school…"

Tries to answer; vocabulary too limited to explain idea; breaks down into fragmented thoughts

What might this sound like?

- *Words are relevant*
- *Repetition, no description*
- *No vocabulary for feelings, reasons, or comparisons*

For example:

Question	***Band 3 Response***
"What do you do in your free time?"	*"I watch movie. I sleep. I play game."*
"Tell me about your hometown."	*"My town big. Have many car. Have food."*
"What kind of music do you like?"	*"I like pop. It is good. I listen every day."*

Band 4

- *Resource sufficient for familiar topics but only basic meaning can be conveyed on unfamiliar topics.*
- *Frequent inappropriacies and errors in word choice.*
- *Rarely attempts paraphrase.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Resource sufficient for familiar topics…**
  - The student has enough vocabulary to speak **simply but understandably** about topics like:
    - Family
    - Hobbies
    - Daily routine
    - Favorite food
    - Personal preferences

Example:

"I like watching movies. My favorite is action movies. I watch at night. It's fun."

Communicates clear message; vocabulary is on-topic; not much variety

- **...but only basic meaning can be conveyed on unfamiliar topics.**
  - If asked about **abstract or less common topics**, they:
    - Use **simple words** incorrectly
    - Give short answers with little detail
    - Struggle to **extend or clarify** their point

Example:

Examiner: "How important is public transport in your country?"
Candidate: "Uh... transport is bus... good. Many people go work... traffic."

Examiner gets the idea; disjointed, lacks vocabulary for proper explanation; can't explain why something is important

- **Frequent inappropriacies and errors in word choice**
  - The candidate **tries to use words**, but often **chooses the wrong ones**.
  - This results in:
    - Awkward phrasing
    - Confusing meaning
    - Misused vocabulary (wrong word for the context)

Example:

*"I enjoy watch the cinema because it is very **relax**. I feel **fresh** after movie."*

Tries to express feeling; "relax" should be "relaxing" or "to relax"; "fresh" is awkward — probably meant "happy" or "better"

- **Rarely attempts paraphrase**
  - When they don't know a word, Band 4 speakers:
    - **Pause or give up**, instead of rephrasing or using an example.
    - May say "I don't know the word" and leave the thought incomplete.

Example:

"Uh... I go to... uh... place with many... uh... animals. I don't know."

Tries to describe a zoo; doesn't attempt a workaround like "It's a place... like park... with animals."

What might this sound like?

- *Some ideas communicated*
- *Frequent errors and awkward phrasing*
- *Limited vocabulary range*
- *No elaboration or paraphrasing*

For example:

Question	*Band 4 Response*
"What do you do in your free time?"	*"I do many things. Like music, and game. I relax. Very fun."*
"Do you prefer cities or countryside?"	*"I like city. Countryside is very… um… no car… but I like city. Is good."*
"Describe your ideal home."	*"My home… big… have many room… TV… sofa… very relax."*

Band 5

- *Resource sufficient to discuss familiar and unfamiliar topics but there is limited flexibility.*
- *Attempts paraphrase but not always with success.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Resource sufficient to discuss familiar and unfamiliar topics…**
  - The candidate can talk about **everyday topics** (family, hobbies, daily life), **and** make a reasonable attempt at **less familiar** ones (technology, the environment, education).
  - Vocabulary is **not impressive**, but it allows for **basic communication** on nearly all IELTS Part 1 & 2 topics, and some Part 3 questions.

  Example:

  "My city has many problems like traffic and pollution. Many people go to work in morning, so the roads are full. Also, the air is not clean."

  The meaning is clear; uses "traffic," "pollution," "clean air" – more than just personal vocabulary; no variety in word choice (e.g., always uses "many" or "problem"); not enough precision (e.g., could say "rush hour," "vehicles," "air quality")

- **…but there is limited flexibility**
  - "Limited flexibility" means the student:
    - Often **sticks to the same safe vocabulary**.
    - **Struggles to use idiomatic or precise language**.
    - May repeat words like "good," "bad," "thing," "problem," instead of choosing a better alternative.
    - Has trouble **adjusting language** for tone or formality.

  Example:

  "The teacher was good. The subject was good too. I learned many good things."

  Communicates the point; repetitive vocabulary; missed chance to say "helpful," "interesting," or "useful"

- **Attempts paraphrase but not always with success**
  - The speaker **tries to explain or describe** a word they don't know.
  - However, the paraphrase:
    - Might be **grammatically incorrect**
    - Might not **clearly communicate the meaning**
    - Might make the sentence more confusing

Example:

"I went to the… um… place where people… they sit… and eat… outside… not in home… you know? For special day."

*The student is **trying to describe a restaurant**; long, unclear, and awkward; needs more control of structures and vocabulary to paraphrase successfully*

What might this sound like?

*Candidates can talk about **a wide range of topics**, but:*

- *They still use **basic or repetitive vocabulary**.*
- *Their word choices may be **inaccurate** or **too general**.*
- *They sometimes **try to rephrase**, but it's often **unclear** or **awkward**.*

For example:

Question	***Band 5 Response***
"What kind of holidays do you enjoy?"	*"I like beach holidays. It's very relaxing. I can swim and sleep. Also, I don't do much. Just… enjoy."*
"How can people protect the environment?"	*"They should not use plastic. And also take bus or train. It help not make bad air."*
"Tell me about a teacher you liked."	*"My teacher in high school. She was good. She help me learn. Always talk nice and teach well."*

- *Communicates clearly*
- *Tries more abstract ideas*
- *Repetitive and general words*
- *Some awkward paraphrasing ("bad air" for pollution)*

Band 6

- *Resource sufficient to discuss topics at length.*
- *Vocabulary use may be inappropriate but meaning is clear.*
- *Generally able to paraphrase successfully.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Resource sufficient to discuss topics at length**
  - The student doesn't run out of words when discussing:
    - Everyday topics like hobbies, work, or hometown
    - Unfamiliar topics like technology, environment, education
  - They can produce **extended answers** and **give opinions or explanations**.

Example:

"I think smartphones are useful because we can communicate quickly. Also, we can use them for maps, taking photos, and even studying. In my opinion, they make life easier."

Detailed; stays on topic; covers more than one idea; basic vocabulary like "useful," "make life easier" — could be more precise

- **Vocabulary use may be inappropriate but meaning is clear**
  - The speaker **sometimes uses the wrong word** (e.g., wrong collocation or register)
  - But the **message is still understandable**
  - Mistakes do **not block communication**, and the listener can **easily guess** the intended meaning

Example:

*"My friend is a very **open-minded** person. He always **hears my feeling** and gives me advice."*

You understand the idea: the friend listens and gives support
"Hears my feeling" is unnatural — better: "listens to me" or "understands how I feel"

- **Generally able to paraphrase successfully**
  - The student **knows when a word is missing** and **tries to explain it** another way
  - They often succeed in:
    - Using synonyms
    - Giving definitions
    - Giving examples or comparisons

Example:

*"In my job, I have to do many **duties**... I mean, responsibilities. Like helping customers or answering calls."*

*Starts with "duties" (a slightly off word), then **paraphrases with "responsibilities"**; clear communication*

What might this sound like?

Candidates:

- *Have **enough vocabulary** to carry on longer, more detailed conversations.*
- *Can **keep going** even if they make **mistakes in word choice**.*
- ***Can rephrase things** when needed — not always perfectly, but usually clearly.*

For example:

Question	***Band 6 Response***
"What's your favorite kind of music?"	*"I enjoy pop music because it's easy to listen and has good rhythm. Also, I can sing with the lyrics and it helps me relax after work."*
"Describe a time when you helped someone."	*"Last month, I helped my friend who was moving house. He had many heavy things, so I helped to carry and organize. He was very happy, and I feel good to help."*
"Why do some people prefer living in cities?"	*"I think cities give more chance for jobs and education. Also, public transportation is better. But sometimes, it's too crowded and noisy."*

- *Responses show **control of everyday vocabulary***
- *Good attempt to explain and support ideas*
- *Some awkward phrasing or overuse of basic vocabulary like "good," "many," "thing," "feel"*

Band 7

- *Resource flexibly used to discuss a variety of topics.*
- *Some ability to use less common and idiomatic items and an awareness of style and collocation is evident though inappropriacies occur.*
- *Effective use of paraphrase as required.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Resource flexibly used to discuss a variety of topics**
  - The speaker can talk comfortably about **a wide range of topics**, including:
    - Personal experiences and preferences
    - Abstract or societal topics (e.g., technology, education, global issues)
  - They can **change vocabulary** depending on the topic and context.
  - They are starting to show **topic sensitivity** — e.g., using formal words in serious contexts and casual ones in informal stories.

  Example:

  "I believe that overreliance on smartphones has diminished people's capacity for face-to-face interaction."

  Complex vocabulary: "overreliance," "diminished," "capacity"; topic-appropriate register; confident tone

- **Some ability to use less common and idiomatic items...though inappropriacies occur**
  - They might use idioms or less frequent words:
    - "I hit the books last night because I had a major exam today."
    - "The movie was quite thought-provoking."
    - "I was over the moon when I passed."
  - Band 7 speakers **attempt** idioms or expressions
  - But may **misuse** some or mix them up

  Example of error:

  "I was full of beans... um, no, I mean... full of joy!"

  Able to correct themselves.

- **... and an awareness of style and collocation is evident though inappropriacies occur**
  - *Style* refers to **formal vs informal** language, depending on the situation.
  - *Collocation* refers to **which words naturally go together**.

  Good:

  "She made a strong impression on the panel." (natural collocation: make an impression)

  Less appropriate:

  "He did a big mistake." (wrong collocation; should be made a big mistake)

- **Effective use of paraphrase as required**
  - *If the student forgets a word, they can **rephrase or describe it effectively**.*
  - *They don't just stop — they **strategize** using other vocabulary.*
  - *Their paraphrases are usually **natural and successful**.*

Example:
"I joined a workshop — you know, a short training event where we learned new skills — on digital marketing last week."

Defines "workshop" with a clear paraphrase; avoids gaps in communication

What might this sound like?

- *Students are **confident speakers** who can handle many everyday and even complex topics.*
- *They use **a good mix of common and uncommon words**, and start sounding more **natural**.*
- *They make **some errors**, especially with collocations and idioms, but overall **communicate clearly** and **adapt their language**.*
- *They **paraphrase successfully** when needed.*

For example:

Question	***Band 7 Response***
"What do you like about your hometown?"	*"It's a lively place with a great mix of modern and traditional culture. The food scene is also incredible — you'll find both street food and fine dining."*
"Describe a time you made a decision that changed your life."	*"I decided to switch careers from finance to education. It was a huge leap, but ultimately it aligned with my values and gave me more purpose."*
"What can individuals do to help protect the environment?"	*"They can adopt sustainable habits, like reducing plastic use, opting for public transport, and supporting eco-friendly brands."*

- *Uses varied vocabulary: "lively," "aligned with my values," "sustainable habits," "opt for"*
- *Slight idiomatic usage: "huge leap"*
- *Might still have occasional awkward phrasing, but it's minor*

Band 8

- *Wide resource, readily and flexibly used to discuss all topics and convey precise meaning.*
- *Skilful use of less common and idiomatic items despite occasional inaccuracies in word choice and collocation.*
- *Effective use of paraphrase as required.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Wide resource, readily and flexibly used to discuss all topics and convey precise meaning**
  - **Wide resource** means they know and **can use** a lot of vocabulary. Not just understand — they actively **apply** it in conversation.
  - **Readily** = they don't struggle or pause too much when choosing words.
  - **Flexibly** = they can adjust their language depending on the situation, topic, or tone.
  - **Precise meaning** = they don't just use general words like "good," "bad," or "thing" — they use **specific vocabulary** that captures their exact meaning.

Example:

"The government implemented stringent regulations to curb the alarming rise in air pollution."

Uses topic-specific words: "stringent," "regulations," "curb," "alarming rise"

Communicates precisely and naturally

- **Skilful use of less common and idiomatic items despite occasional inaccuracies in word choice and collocation**
  - Less common and idiomatic items:
    - These are:
      - **Less common vocabulary**: "compelling," "multifaceted," "to exacerbate"
      - **Idioms**: "a blessing in disguise," "in the long run," "on the same wavelength"
      - **Phrasal verbs**: "carry out," "bring up," "look into"
    - Band 8 speakers use them **effectively** and **in the right context** most of the time.
  - They may still say something like "make a big fault" instead of "make a big mistake" — but these errors are rare and don't cause confusion.
  - Even strong speakers may **occasionally choose the wrong partner word**, but it does **not interfere** with meaning.

- **Effective use of paraphrase as required**
  - *When the speaker forgets or doesn't know a specific word, they can:*
    - *Describe it*
    - *Compare it*
    - *Give an example*
  - *This is done **smoothly** and doesn't interrupt their fluency.*

Example:

"I'm not sure what it's called, but it's the process where water turns into vapor — you know, when it gets heated."

Natural, informative paraphrase; keeps the conversation flowing

What might this sound like?

Student:

- *Has a **large vocabulary** they can **use confidently** across many topics.*
- *Uses **natural, idiomatic English** — just like a native or near-native speaker would.*
- *Can explain and describe things **clearly and precisely**, even when the topic is abstract or unfamiliar.*
- *May still make **a few small mistakes**, but they don't affect understanding.*
- *Can **rephrase and paraphrase** when necessary, **with ease**.*

For example:

Question	*Band 8 Response*
"What do you enjoy about your job?"	*"I thrive on the variety it offers. Each day presents new challenges that stimulate critical thinking and creativity."*
"Do you think schools should focus more on technology?"	*"Absolutely. Integrating digital tools enhances engagement and better prepares students for a tech-driven workforce."*
"Describe a difficult decision you made."	*"Relocating overseas was daunting, but ultimately it broadened my horizons and pushed me out of my comfort zone."*

- *Advanced vocabulary: "thrive," "stimulate," "daunting," "broadened my horizons"*
- *Use of idioms and figurative speech: "pushed me out of my comfort zone"*
- *Tone-appropriate and precise*

Band 9

- *Total flexibility and precise use in all contexts.*
- *Sustained use of accurate and idiomatic language.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Total flexibility and precise use in all contexts**
  - **Total flexibility** means the speaker can:
    - Adjust their word choices to suit **formal, informal, or academic** contexts.
    - Shift tone depending on the topic (e.g., light when talking about hobbies, serious when discussing climate change).
    - Choose from a wide range of synonyms depending on *exact* meaning.

  Example:

  "I find city living invigorating—it fuels my creativity, though I do sometimes yearn for the tranquillity of rural life."

  Vocabulary shows nuance: "invigorating," "yearn," "tranquillity"; used precisely and naturally

- **Sustained use of accurate and idiomatic language**
  - **Sustained** = they do this **throughout** the entire Speaking test.
  - **Idiomatic language** includes:
    - Common expressions used naturally: *"on the same wavelength," "jump the gun," "a bit of a stretch"*
    - Phrasal verbs used correctly: *"bring up a concern," "work something out," "wind down after work"*
  - **Accurate** = no strange word combinations, incorrect idioms, or mistranslations.

  Example:

  "I wouldn't say I'm a morning person per se, but once I've had my coffee, I'm good to go."

  Natural idiomatic expression; no hesitation or awkwardness; tone is conversational and fluid

What might this sound like?

Student:

- *Has a **master-level command of vocabulary**.*
- *Can **easily** and **precisely** express any idea in **any topic**, whether familiar or abstract.*
- *Uses **idiomatic expressions, collocations, and less common words** accurately and naturally—not memorized, but integrated seamlessly.*
- *Maintains **this level** of vocabulary use throughout the test—not just once or twice, but sustained across all questions.*

For example:

Part 1: Personal Questions

Q: "Do you prefer working alone or in a team?"

A: "It depends on the task, but generally, I thrive in collaborative settings. Bouncing ideas off others often leads to more well-rounded solutions, though I do appreciate solo work when deep focus is needed."

- *Precise verbs: "thrive," "bouncing ideas off others"*
- *Natural idiom: "bouncing ideas off"*

Part 2: Long Turn

Q: "Describe a project you worked on recently."

A: "I recently spearheaded a marketing campaign aimed at rebranding a mid-sized local business. It was a multifaceted effort involving content strategy, social media, and customer engagement. What made it particularly rewarding was the opportunity to think creatively while staying grounded in practical business outcomes."

- *Lexical precision: "spearheaded," "multifaceted," "grounded"*
- *Sustained high-level vocabulary*
- *No awkward or forced language*

Part 3: Two-way Discussion

Q: "Do you think young people today face more challenges than in the past?"
A: "Absolutely. While technological advancements have opened up countless doors, they've also ushered in a wave of mental health issues, social disconnection, and information overload. The pressure to curate a perfect online persona can be exhausting."

- *Idiomatic: "opened up countless doors," "ushered in a wave," "curate a perfect persona"*
- *High precision*
- *Sophisticated tone*

C. Grammatical Range and Accuracy

"Grammatical Range and Accuracy" refers to **how much variety** and **how correctly** a speaker uses **grammar** in the Speaking test. It's not just about avoiding mistakes — it's also about showing **control** and **flexibility** with sentence structures.

*Key Indicators of **Grammatical Range***

Length of spoken sentences

- Are they just using very short sentences like:
  - *"I like pizza." / "It is hot." / "I went there."*
- Or do they use **longer, connected thoughts**?
  - *"Although I like pizza, I try not to eat it too often because it's unhealthy."*

💡 Long doesn't always mean better — but longer, correctly structured sentences show higher proficiency.

Subordinate clauses

- These are phrases that **add detail or cause/effect**, like:
  - *"because I was tired"*
  - *"although I didn't enjoy it"*
  - *"which I bought last year"*
- **More frequent** use of clauses like *if, because, although, when, which, that*.
  - Example: *"I decided to study abroad **because** I wanted to improve my English."*

Complex verb phrases

- Does the speaker **use the correct verb forms**, such as:
  - **Perfect aspect:** *"I have lived here for five years."*
  - **Continuous aspect:** *"I've been studying since morning."*
  - **Modals:** *"I might go later."*
  - **Passive voice:** *"It was built in the 1800s."*

Pre- and post-modification

- This refers to extra details **before or after nouns** or adjectives.
  - **Pre-modification**: *"an expensive Italian leather sofa"*
  - **Post-modification**: *"a man who works in a hospital"*

Flexibility in sentence structures

- Can the speaker move parts around for emphasis or variety?
  - *"It was pizza that I really wanted."* (cleft sentence for focus)
  - *"Not only is it easy to cook, but it's also delicious."* (inversion for emphasis)

*Key Indicators of **Grammatical Accuracy***

Error density

- This is about **how many mistakes** the speaker makes, and whether the mistakes **affect understanding**.
- How many grammar mistakes appear in a given stretch of speech?
  - *Band 3–4*: Frequent and noticeable errors.
  - *Band 5*: Errors are common, especially in complex sentences, but don't often block meaning.
  - *Band 6–9*: Mistakes are less frequent and typically don't affect clarity.

Effect of errors on communication

- Do the grammar mistakes **confuse the listener**?
- Do they **require listener effort** to understand the message?

💡 A few small errors that don't interfere with communication are acceptable at higher bands. But if the listener has to guess or ask for clarification, the band will drop.

JIC Scoresheet

Grammatical Range and Accuracy

Word Forms

Qualifying

What it is	Using the **correct form of the word** in a sentence (verb, noun, adjective, adverb). ➤ *Example*: "He is a fast runner" vs "He is a fastly runner"
How to check	Listen for errors like: ● Incorrect adjective/adverb forms ● Using verbs instead of nouns (e.g., "I decision it" instead of "I decided")

Sentence Forms / Structure

Qualifying

What it is	The student uses a **variety of sentence structures**, such as: ● Simple: "I like pizza." ● Compound: "I like pizza, and I also enjoy pasta." ● Complex: "Although I like pizza, I try not to eat it too often."
How to check	Note if student uses only short/simple sentences, or if they're attempting longer, more complex ones—even with errors.

Grammar Control

Qualifying and Quantifying

What it is	This refers to how **accurately grammar is used overall**—tenses, agreement, prepositions, articles, etc.
How to check	Listen for subject-verb agreement, verb tense use, articles, and prepositions. Do errors impact understanding? ● **Quantifying**: How frequent are the mistakes? ● **Qualifying**: How severe are the mistakes?

Tenses

Qualifying and Quantifying

What it is	Using the **correct verb tense** for time and meaning. ➤ *Example*: "I **have lived** here for five years" vs "I **live** here for five years"
How to check	Focus on errors related to: ● Present perfect vs simple past ● Future vs present ● Consistency within an answer Do they mix up tenses? Or switch tenses accurately depending on the topic?

Band Scores Explained

Grammatical Range and Accuracy

Band 1

- *No rateable language unless memorised.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **No rateable language...**
  - This means the examiner **cannot judge** any grammar because:
    - There is not enough spoken language.
    - The utterances are **too limited** to demonstrate grammar use.
    - The words do not show how the learner builds or understands sentence structure.
  - Think of it as: **"There's nothing to evaluate."**

- **...unless memorised**
  - Some candidates may speak, but only:
    - **Pre-learned responses** from a script.
    - **Phrases taught in class**, like:
      - "I like pizza."
      - "My favourite color is blue."
      - "I live in [City]."
  - These don't reflect actual ability if the candidate **cannot use them in other situations or change them**.

What might this sound like?

A candidate at Band 1 **cannot produce original spoken sentences**. If they speak at all, the words are usually:

- **Isolated**, **memorised**, or **learned as fixed phrases** (like "How are you?" or "My name is...")
- **Not combined into full sentences**
- **Not enough to show their real grammar ability**

They **cannot form grammatical structures** on their own and may only say things they have rehearsed or copied.

In short: **no real grammar is being used**, or if it is, it is extremely limited and copied.

For example:

> *Examiner: "What do you like to do in your free time?"*
>
> *Candidate: "Free time... pizza... uhh... I go... blue... no."*

This shows:

- ***No complete sentences***
- ***No grammatical structure***
- ***No control over verb tenses or word order***

Another example:

> *Candidate: "I student. Uh... I... my name is student. OK."*

Or they may say nothing at all.

Band 2

- *No evidence of basic sentence forms.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **No evidence of basic sentence forms**
  - **"Sentence forms"** means: subject + verb (+ object).
    - e.g., "I eat breakfast."
  - **"No evidence"** means: you **don't hear anything that shows this structure is understood or being attempted.**
  - Students may try to speak, but they're not **joining the words in meaningful ways**.

What might this sound like?

The candidate **cannot produce even the most basic sentence structures**, such as:

- "I like music."
- "She is a teacher."
- "They live in Japan."

They might say:

- Just **single words** ("music", "like", "Japan")
- Or **broken phrases** without structure ("I like. Japan.")

If they attempt sentences, the **grammar is too broken** to make sense or to evaluate accurately.

In short: **they are trying**, but **nothing resembles real sentence grammar yet**.

> *For example*:
>
> *Examiner: Where do you live?*
>
> *Candidate: "Live… home… Manila… me."*
>
> *Examiner: What do you like to do on weekends?*
>
> *Candidate: "I like… uh… dance… no… music… yes…"*

Even though there are **attempts**, you'll notice:

- No **clear subject-verb-object** pattern.
- No **tense control** (e.g., "live" but no subject).
- Broken chunks of language, not real sentences.

Band 3

- *Basic sentence forms are attempted but grammatical errors are numerous except in apparently memorised utterances.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Basic sentence forms are attempted**
  - The student **tries to form full sentences** using basic grammar:
    - **Subject + verb** (e.g., "I like music.")
    - **Subject + verb + object** (e.g., "He eats rice.")
  - May attempt simple past or present tenses

But…

- **Grammatical errors are numerous**
  - Most of these attempts have **errors**, like:
    - **Incorrect word order**: "She go school."
    - **Wrong verb tense**: "Yesterday I go to park."
    - **Omitted articles or auxiliaries**: "I student." / "He playing."

These errors are **so frequent** that grammar cannot be considered **accurate** or even **partially reliable**.

- **Except in apparently memorised utterances**
  - Some sentences might be correct—but they are **clearly memorised** from a book, class, or app:
    - "I'm 20 years old."
    - "My name is Anna."
    - "I live in Manila."

These don't show grammar ability because the student **cannot apply the same structure to new topics**.

What might this sound like?

This student:

- **Tries to make sentences** (unlike Band 2), but
- **Makes a lot of grammar mistakes**, which often:
  - Make the sentence **unclear**, or
  - **Interrupt** communication
- May have **some correct phrases**, but they sound **memorised** (e.g., "My favorite color is blue")

In short: the student **has the idea of how sentences work**, but **their grammar is weak** and **inconsistent**.

For example:

Examiner: Do you work or are you a student?

Candidate: I working. No, I work. I student—before. Now no.

Examiner: What do you usually do on weekends?

Candidate: I go mall. And uh… meet my friend. He like… we together. Eat.

- Attempts sentence forms (subject + verb).
- Frequent grammatical mistakes: wrong verb forms, no articles, broken sentence links.
- Communicative **intention is there**, but grammar is a **barrier**.

Band 4

- *Can produce basic sentence forms and some short utterances are error-free.*
- *Subordinate clauses are rare and, overall, turns are short, structures are repetitive and errors are frequent.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Can produce basic sentence forms and some short utterances are error-free**
  - The student is capable of making correct, short sentences:
    - "I like music."
    - "She goes to school."
    - "I watched a movie."

- **Subordinate clauses are rare**
  - Subordinate clauses = clauses that **add detail** and **depend** on a main clause:
    - Examples:

        - "Because I was tired, I went home."
        - "When I have time, I watch movies."
    - At Band 4, students **don't really use these**. If they try, they're often incorrect or fragmented:
        - "Because tired, I go home."
        - "I watch movie… when… time have."

- **Turns are short, structures are repetitive and errors are frequent**
    - **Turns are short**: They don't speak for long stretches. They may say one or two short sentences per answer.
    - **Structures are repetitive**: They repeat the same sentence types like:
        - "I like…"
        - "I go to…"
        - "She is…"
    - **Errors are frequent**: They might get basic grammar right occasionally, but **mistakes are still common**, especially with:
        - Verb tense
        - Plurals
        - Articles
        - Subject-verb agreement
        - Prepositions

What might this sound like?

Speaker can:

- **Use short, simple sentences**
- Occasionally say something **without any grammar mistake**
- But they **don't use complex grammar** (like "because," "although," or "when")
- They repeat the same sentence types
- They make **frequent grammar mistakes**

The speaker shows they **know how grammar works**, but can't yet **sustain accuracy** or **vary their grammar structures**.

For example:

Examiner: What do you do on weekends?

Candidate: On weekend, I go shopping. I like shopping. My friend go too. We eat food. Is good.

Examiner: Tell me about your hometown.

Candidate: My hometown is big. Many people. It have park. I like the park. It's nice.

- Basic grammar is there.
- Some short phrases are correct.
- Frequent grammar mistakes:
    - "My friend go" → "My friend goes"
    - "It have park" → "It has a park"
- No use of complex grammar or extended sentences.

Band 5

- *Basic sentence forms are fairly well controlled for accuracy.*
- *Complex structures are attempted but these are limited in range, nearly always contain errors and may lead to the need for reformulation.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Basic sentence forms are fairly well controlled for accuracy**
  - This means they can correctly use:
    - Present simple: *"I work in a school."*
    - Past simple: *"I visited my grandmother."*
    - Future: *"I will go tomorrow."*
  - "Fairly well controlled" = Not perfect, but usually accurate

- **Complex structures are attempted…**
  - **Subordinate clauses**:
    "I stayed home because it was raining."
  - **Conditionals**:
    "If I have time, I'll call you."
  - **Relative clauses**:
    "The person who helped me was kind."

- **…but these are limited in range, nearly always contain errors and may lead to the need for reformulation**
  - They don't know **many** complex structures yet ("limited in range")
  - When they try to use them, they usually make **grammar mistakes**
  - Sometimes, they **start a sentence**, realize it's wrong, and **start again** in a simpler way
    → This is called **reformulation**

  Example:

  "I… I think the movie, who I watched, no… *that I watched was good."*

  Reformulated mid-sentence

What might this sound like?

- Use **basic grammar correctly** most of the time
- **Try** to use more complex sentences (e.g. using **"because"**, **"although"**, or relative clauses like **"who"**, **"that"**)
- But when they try more complex grammar, it's usually **wrong** or **confusing**
- They often have to **stop and fix** what they said (called "reformulation")

  For example:

  Examiner: Tell me about your best friend.

  Candidate: My best friend is Anna. She is very kind and funny. We meet every week. She help… helps me when I have problem. She's person… the person who always understand me.

  Examiner: What did you do last weekend?

  Candidate: I went to my uncle's house. We eat… ate lunch together. Then we go to park. Because the weather was nice, we stay outside long time.

- Uses past tense, present tense
- Tries complex grammar: *"Because the weather was nice,"* and *"who always understand me"*
- Subject-verb agreement errors (*"she help"*)
- Word form errors (*"long time"* instead of *"for a long time"*)
- Complex grammar often needs correction or is used incorrectly

Band 6

- *Produces a mix of short and complex sentence forms and a variety of structures with limited flexibility.*
- *Though errors frequently occur in complex structures, these rarely impede communication.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Produces a mix of short and complex sentence forms…**
  - The student can use:
    - Short/simple: *"I like watching movies."*
    - Complex: *"Although I was tired, I finished the report."*

- **…and a variety of structures with limited flexibility.**
  - They use different sentence types:
    - **Conditional**: *"If I have time, I will go."*
    - **Relative clauses**: *"The person who helped me was kind."*
    - **Adverbial clauses**: *"After I finished, I went home."*
  - However, **limited flexibility** means:
    - They don't switch structures easily
    - They often **rely on familiar patterns**
    - When pushed into unfamiliar topics, they struggle to apply grammar in new ways

- **Though errors frequently occur in complex structures…**
  - Errors are **normal** at this level, especially when:
    - Using long sentences
    - Trying new grammar forms
  - **Example errors:**
    - *"If I will have time, I will go."* (should be: *"If I have time…"*)
    - *"The man which helped me…"* (should be: *"who helped me"*)
  - Still, it's a **good sign** they are **attempting complex grammar**.

- **…these rarely impede communication.**
  - You can still understand what they mean.
  - Even if the grammar is wrong, the listener can follow the idea:
    - *"Although he tired, he go to work."*
      → Grammatically wrong
      → Message is clear: *He was tired, but he still went to work.*

What might this sound like?

- Use both **simple and complex sentences**
- Try **a range of grammar structures**
- But they don't always **use them flexibly** (they stick to what they know)
- Make **frequent grammar mistakes**, especially in longer or more difficult sentences
- However, you can **still understand what they're saying**

For example:

Examiner: *Tell me about your hometown.*

Candidate: *My hometown is small city. It is located in north part of country. I love it because even it is not big, people are very friendly. The place where I live now is far from there, but I visit sometimes.*

Examiner: What do you do on weekends?

Candidate: I usually rest or go out with my friends. If I don't have money, I just stay at home and watch movies. Sometimes I meet my cousin who live near my house — sorry, who lives near my house.

- Uses **complex grammar**: *"Even it is not big…", "If I don't have money…"*
- **Self-corrects minor mistakes**
- Tries **relative clauses** and **conditionals**
- Incorrect grammar use (*"even it is not big"* → should be *"even though it is not big"*)
- **Subject-verb agreement** errors (*"my cousin who live"*)
- Slight confusion in clause construction

Band 7

- *A range of structures flexibly used.*
- *Error-free sentences are frequent.*
- *Both simple and complex sentences are used effectively despite some errors.*
- *A few basic errors persist.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **A range of structures flexibly used**
  - The speaker shows **control and choice** in grammar.
  - They can naturally switch between:
    - **Tenses**: present, past, future
    - **Clauses**: conditionals, relative clauses, adverbial clauses
    - **Passive and active voice**
    - **Modal verbs**: can, could, should, might
    - **Complex forms**: inversion, cleft sentences (at times)
  - "Flexibly used" means they're not just repeating memorized grammar.
  - They choose the structure **based on the situation** and use it **with ease**.

- **Error-free sentences are frequent**
  - At Band 7, **many complete sentences have zero grammar mistakes**.
  - Not *all* sentences are perfect — but **you can expect several clean, well-formed ones in every response**.

- **Both simple and complex sentences are used effectively despite some errors**
  - The speaker uses a **balance of sentence types**:
    - **Simple**: "I enjoy reading."
    - **Complex**: "Although I didn't like it at first, I eventually found it useful."
  - Some errors may still happen, especially when the student experiments or speaks quickly:
    - Preposition slips (*"discuss about" instead of "discuss"*)
    - Articles (*"a advice" instead of "some advice"*)
    - Plurals or subject-verb agreement errors
  - But **these mistakes don't damage the clarity or overall grammar quality**.

- **A few basic errors persist**
  - Even advanced speakers still make **little mistakes**, especially under pressure.
    These are not major flaws, but **consistent small slips**:
    - *"He give me advice"* (should be *"gives"*)
    - *"I go to shopping"* (should be *"go shopping"*)
    - *"My friend she is very kind"* (double subject)

- The key is: **they're not making the same mistake over and over**, and the listener can still clearly understand them.

What might this sound like?

- Uses **different types of grammar structures** with confidence
- Uses **both simple and complex sentences** effectively
- Can speak **naturally and flexibly**, not just memorized
- Makes **some errors**, but they **don't interfere** with communication
- **Occasional basic mistakes** may still happen (e.g., articles, plurals, prepositions)

For example:

Examiner: What do you usually do on weekends?

Candidate: Well, it depends. Sometimes I prefer staying at home because I need to rest, especially after a stressful week. But if the weather is nice, I go hiking with my friends. I also try to do some household chores, which I usually postpone during the week.

Examiner: What kind of TV programs do you enjoy?

Candidate: I tend to watch documentaries or science shows. I find them really interesting, and they help me learn new things. Although I used to enjoy sitcoms, nowadays I feel that they are a bit repetitive. If I have time, I watch a movie with my family, which is a good way to relax and bond.

- Complex sentences: *"Although I used to enjoy…", "If I have time…"*
- Passive voice: *"which I usually postpone…"*
- Correct tense choices and conditionals

Band 8

- *Wide range of structures, flexibly used.*
- *The majority of sentences are error-free.*
- *Occasional inappropriacies and non-systematic errors occur.*
- *A few basic errors may persist.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Wide range of structures, flexibly used**
  - This means the speaker uses:
    - A broad variety of **sentence forms** (simple, compound, complex, conditional, passive, etc.)
    - A range of **grammatical tools** (modals, relative clauses, inversions, hedging)
    - All of this in a way that feels **natural and appropriate to the situation**
  - *"Flexibly used"* means the speaker **chooses the right grammar** to express their ideas — not just because they memorized it, but because it fits what they're saying.

Example:

"Although I'd originally planned to stay in, I ended up going out because the weather was too nice to ignore."

This sentence shows control of structure, variety, and natural flow.

- **The majority of sentences are error-free**
  - Most full sentences — especially the ones that are **not memorized** — are **correctly formed**:
    - Subjects and verbs agree
    - Tenses are well-controlled
    - Articles, prepositions, and pronouns are mostly accurate
  - Even when the student speaks quickly or about complex topics, they **rarely make mistakes**.

- **Occasional inappropriacies and non-systematic errors occur**
  - **Inappropriacy** = using the wrong form or style of grammar (e.g., too casual or too formal, or slightly unnatural usage)
    - *"He was very kind person."* ← article mistake (should be *"a very kind person"*)
    - *"I very like it."* ← collocation error (should be *"I really like it"*)
  - **Non-systematic errors** = errors that happen randomly — not because the speaker doesn't understand, but maybe because they're speaking quickly or lost focus.
  - These **don't happen in a pattern**, and the student **can usually correct them** if given time.

- **A few basic errors may persist**
  - Even at Band 8, **small basic errors** might still show up:
    - Article misuse (*"an advice"*)
    - Preposition slips (*"married with" instead of *"married to"*)
    - Verb forms (*"he go"* instead of *"he goes"*)
  - The key is:
    - They don't happen often
    - They don't reduce clarity
    - They don't appear systematic (i.e., they don't always make the same mistake)

What might this sound like?

- Uses **a wide variety of grammar structures** and chooses the right one naturally.
- Produces **mostly error-free sentences**.
- Occasionally makes **small or awkward grammar mistakes**, but **not repeatedly**.
- May still make **a few basic grammar slips**, but these are very rare.

For example:

Examiner: Do you prefer working alone or in a team?

Candidate: It depends on the nature of the task. When I'm writing or doing analytical work, I tend to prefer working alone because I can focus better. But for creative projects or brainstorming, collaborating with others usually leads to more innovative ideas. Although there can be some conflict in team settings, I think the benefits outweigh the challenges.

- Mix of tenses and clauses
- Correct use of conditionals (*"Although there can be…"*)
- Passive construction (*"the benefits outweigh the challenges"*)

Band 9

- *Structures are precise and accurate at all times, apart from 'mistakes' characteristic of native speaker speech.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Structures are precise and accurate at all times**
  - Sentences are not just "correct" — they are **clearly, accurately chosen** for the task or idea.
  - Candidate can use advanced forms such as:
    - Conditional sentences (*"Had I known, I would have…"*)
    - Relative clauses (*"the person who helped me…"*)
    - Cleft sentences (*"What I like most is…"*)
    - Passive voice (*"The decision was made…"*)
    - Subjunctive mood (*"If I were you…"*)
  - They don't just attempt these — they use them *correctly and effortlessly*.

- **Apart from 'mistakes' characteristic of native speaker speech**
  - This is a **very specific phrase**. It means that:
    - **Some errors might still occur**, but they're **not real grammar mistakes** — they're the **natural slip-ups** even fluent native speakers make when speaking quickly or casually.

  Examples:

    - *Self-correction mid-sentence*
      - *"There's — there are two options I'm considering."*
    - *Minor agreement slips*
      - *"There's lots of people who…" ← very common in native speech.*

  - These are **not penalized** at Band 9, because they don't reflect a *lack of knowledge*, but the **normal rhythm of fluent conversation**.

What might this sound like?

- Uses **a wide variety of sentence structures**, including complex and advanced forms.
- Makes **very few to no grammar mistakes** — and if they do, it's the kind of "natural mistake" even **native speakers** make in casual speech.
- Shows **complete control of grammar** to express ideas precisely and fluently.
- Sounds **natural, accurate, and native-like** — both in complexity and correctness.

  For example:

  Examiner: What kinds of things make people feel stressed these days?

  Candidate: Well, I suppose that depends on the individual, but broadly speaking, issues like job security, financial uncertainty, and even the pressure to maintain a work-life balance contribute significantly. What's particularly interesting is that, despite technological advancements aimed at convenience, many people actually report feeling more overwhelmed than ever.

- Grammatical features present:
  - Embedded clauses
  - Cleft structure (*"What's particularly interesting is…"*)
  - Passive voice (*"are aimed at"*)
  - Conditionals implied (*"despite…" structures show contrast fluently*)
- All of this is done **without hesitation or error**.

D. Pronunciation

In IELTS, **pronunciation** doesn't mean sounding British or American — it means:

- **Speaking clearly enough to be understood**.
- **Using the features of spoken English** to make your message easy to follow and expressive.

IELTS *does not penalize* you for having an accent — **as long as your accent does not interfere with understanding**.

*Key Indicators of **Pronunciation***

Chunking

Definition: Breaking speech into natural, meaningful parts — like breathing pauses or phrases.

Good example:

"When I was a child // I used to play // in the park every day."

Poor example (no chunking, sounds robotic):

"WhenIwasachildIusedtoplayintheparkeveryday."

💡 **Why it matters:** Without chunking, listeners can't follow your ideas. It's like reading one very long sentence with no punctuation.

Rhythm and stress timing

Definition: English is a stress-timed language — meaning we **stress some syllables** and **reduce others** to create rhythm.

Good example:

*"I **WENT** to the **STORE** to buy some **MILK**."* (stressed content words)

Poor example:

"I WENT TO THE STORE TO BUY SOME MILK." (everything stressed = unnatural)

💡 **Why it matters:** Native-like rhythm helps listeners predict what's coming, making speech easier to process.

Connected speech

Definition: English sounds are often **linked** or **reduced** in fast, fluent speech.

Includes:

- **Linking**: *go on → go_on*
- **Elision** (dropping a sound): *friends → fren's*
- **Intrusion**: *go out → go_wout*

Example:

“Do_you_want_to_go?”

💡 **Why it matters:** Helps learners sound more fluent and native-like. Also helps the *listener* follow speech better.

JIC Scoresheet

Pronunciation

Mispronunciation

Qualifying

What it is	Incorrect pronunciation of words—can be vowel/consonant errors or syllable stress. ➤ *Example*: saying **"desart"** instead of **"dessert"**, or **"ree-sume"** instead of **"résumé"**.
How to check	Does the error **change the meaning** or make it hard to understand? Minor slips (e.g., slight "th" errors) are forgivable unless they happen frequently.

Incomplete Word Endings

Quantifying and Qualifying

What it is	Dropping the last sound of a word, common with past tense **-ed** endings or plural **-s**. ➤ *Example*: saying "walk" instead of "walked"
How to check	Track the number of missing endings that affect clarity or grammatical understanding.

Stress and Intonation

Qualifying

What it is	• **Stress:** Emphasis on the correct syllable or word. • **Intonation:** Natural rising and falling of the voice (e.g., rising for questions).
How to check	• **Word Stress:** Do they say "re**CORD**" (noun) vs "re**cord**" (verb) correctly? • **Sentence Stress:** Are content words emphasized (nouns, verbs) instead of grammar words? • **Intonation:** Does it rise and fall appropriately or sound flat and robotic?

Accent

Qualifying

What it is	Everyone has an accent. This checks **whether their accent interferes with understanding**.
How to check	Is the accent so strong it causes confusion or mishearing? If not, it's fine—even native speakers have accents.

Voice Quality

Qualifying

What it is	The clarity, tone, and breath control in the voice.
How to check	Are they speaking too softly? Too fast? Too monotone? Any raspiness or over-nasal tone that affects clarity?

Voice Inflection

Voice Inflection

Qualifying

What it is	Related to intonation; changes in pitch that show emotion, questioning, contrast, or emphasis.
How to check	Does the voice rise/fall naturally? Or is it flat/monotonous? A more expressive voice = higher band.

Band Scores Explained

Pronunciation

Band 1

- *Can produce occasional individual words and phonemes that are recognisable, but no overall meaning is conveyed.*
- *Unintelligible.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- Is **almost completely impossible to understand**.
- May say **a few English sounds or words**, but they **don't make complete or understandable sentences**.
- Cannot **communicate ideas**, because the listener **cannot follow the speech**.
- Is likely **not familiar with English pronunciation** at all, or has **extreme pronunciation issues**.

Category	Description
Word-level clarity	May say a word or two correctly (e.g., "hello"), but most words are mispronounced.
Sentence-level clarity	There is no sentence-level meaning — phrases are unintelligible.
Overall understanding	The listener cannot understand what the candidate is trying to say.
Phoneme production	Occasionally, individual sounds (phonemes) are correct, but these are not consistent or connected.
Accent interference	Likely has very strong interference from their first language (L1), to the point that it blocks communication.

What might this sound like?

For example:

> *Let's say the candidate is trying to say:*
>
> > *"I am from China and I like to travel."*
>
> *But what comes out is something like:*
>
> > *"Ah… fom… ka-na… eh… traa…" (mumbled, no rhythm, unclear consonants or vowels)*

- The listener cannot figure out what the candidate means.
- Even **context clues don't help**.
- The **speech lacks intonation, stress, rhythm**, and has **mispronunciations of almost every word**.

Band 2

- *Uses few acceptable phonological features (possibly because sample is insufficient).*
- *Overall problems with delivery impair attempts at connected speech.*
- *Individual words and phonemes are mainly mispronounced and little meaning is conveyed.*
- *Often unintelligible.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- Is **almost completely impossible to understand**.
- May say **a few English sounds or words**, but they **don't make complete or understandable sentences**.
- Cannot **communicate ideas**, because the listener **cannot follow the speech**.
- Is likely **not familiar with English pronunciation** at all, or has **extreme pronunciation issues**.

Category	Description
Sounds / Phonemes	Mostly incorrect (e.g., confusing /b/ and /v/, /l/ and /r/)
Word stress	Random or missing; wrong syllables emphasized
Speech rhythm	No natural flow — every word may sound like it's spoken in isolation
Connected speech	Absent — sounds disconnected and robotic
Understanding	Listener struggles to understand, even in common topics
Communication	Barely possible; listener must guess often

- What Are "Phonological Features"?
  - These are the sound systems of English that make speech flow and sound natural:
    - **Word stress**: e.g., TAble, not taBLE
    - **Sentence stress**: Which word is emphasized in a sentence?
      - "I didn't *say* you stole it." vs "I didn't say *you* stole it."
    - **Intonation**: Voice rising or falling to show emotion or grammar
    - **Connected speech**: Linking, contractions, weak forms
      - "What are you doing?" → *"Whatcha doin'?"*

What might this sound like?

For example:

Let's say they're trying to say:

"I went to the market yesterday."

It might sound like:

"Eye... uh... wet... tuh... ma... ka... test... uh... day."

- Individual words are mostly mispronounced.
- There's **no connected rhythm**.
- Listener has to guess heavily based on context.
- They may say some **memorized phrases**, but still mispronounce them.

Band 3

- *Displays some features of Band 2, and some, but not all, of the positive features of Band 4.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- Can sometimes be understood, but **many parts of their speech are unclear**.
- May **occasionally** use stress or intonation — but **inconsistently**.
- **Most words are still mispronounced**, especially those not memorized.
- They try to connect words or use rhythm, but it's **not reliable**.
- The listener has to **work hard to understand**, and **frequent clarification is needed**.

Category	Description
Phonological features	Rarely correct. May try using intonation or stress, but often fails.
Chunking (speech grouping)	May pause in unnatural places or group words incorrectly.
Word/sound clarity	**Frequent mispronunciations**, especially in longer or unfamiliar words.
Overall rhythm	Disjointed. Does not sound like natural English rhythm.
Intelligibility	Some parts are clear, but **large portions** are hard or impossible to understand.

What might this sound like?

For example:

Let's take the sentence:

"I study engineering at university."

What Band 3 might sound like:

"I... uh... stu... eh... en-gin... ear... uni... uh... sit... ree..."

- **Mispronounced stress**: "engin-EAR-ing" instead of "engi-NEER-ing"
- **Broken rhythm**: unnatural pauses
- **Individual word clarity**: only "I" and "study" are semi-clear

Band 4

- *Uses some acceptable phonological features, but the range is limited.*
- *Produces some acceptable chunking, but there are frequent lapses in overall rhythm.*
- *Attempts to use intonation and stress, but control is limited.*
- *Individual words or phonemes are frequently mispronounced, causing lack of clarity.*
- *Understanding requires some effort and there may be patches of speech that cannot be understood.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- Are **understandable in short bursts**, but require frequent effort from the listener.
- Use some English pronunciation patterns, but **inconsistently**.
- May **attempt stress or intonation**, but don't control them well.
- **Still mispronounce many sounds**, especially when speaking naturally.
- Their speech **doesn't flow well** — it may sound choppy or robotic.

Category	Description
Phonological features	Present, but inconsistent. Some stress/intonation is there, but not reliably.
Chunking & Rhythm	Tries to group words correctly, but frequent rhythm breakdowns.
Word clarity	Many mispronunciations still. Listener has to guess frequently.
Intonation & Stress	Occasionally used, but not always meaningfully or naturally.
Comprehensibility	**Most of the speech can be understood** with effort, but **some parts may still be lost**.

What might this sound like?

For example:

> *Let's take the sentence:*
>
> > *"I study engineering at university."*
>
> *They might say:*
>
> > *"I stuh-dy enjin-earing at… un-i-var-si-tee."*

- Still some **stress and vowel errors**, but **closer to actual words**.
- Rhythm is broken, but **improved** from Band 3.
- Listener can **understand the full sentence with effort**.

Band 5

- *Displays some features of Band 4, and some, but not all, of the positive features of Band 6.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Some phonological features** (like stress, intonation, rhythm) are used, but often **incorrectly or inconsistently**.
- **Mispronunciations are still frequent**, especially in longer or less familiar words.
- **Listeners can understand most of what's said**, but they may need to **focus harder** and **ask for clarification** sometimes.
- **Speech lacks smoothness** — pauses, unnatural stress, and robotic rhythm are common

Category	Description
Phonological features	Some attempt at English-like speech, but control is weak.
Chunking & Rhythm	Not natural. Stress is misplaced or uneven.
Stress & Intonation	Used in parts, but with **frequent errors or flat delivery**.
Word/Phoneme Clarity	**Still has many mispronunciations**, especially of consonant clusters (e.g., "spl", "thr") or vowels.
Intelligibility	Mostly understandable, but **listener effort is required**, especially in faster or spontaneous speech.

What might this sound like?

For example:

> *Let's take the sentence:*
>
> > *"I usually go shopping with my friends on weekends."*
>
> *They might sound like:*
>
> > *"I… yoo-sually go… shop-ing… weeth my… frens… on week-end."*

- *Mispronunciation: "yoo-sually" instead of "usually"*
- *Flat or misplaced stress*
- *Slightly robotic pacing*
- *Still understandable, but effort is needed*

Band 6

- *Uses a range of phonological features, but control is variable.*
- *Chunking is generally appropriate, but rhythm may be affected by a lack of stress-timing and/or a rapid speech rate.*
- *Some effective use of intonation and stress, but this is not sustained.*
- *Individual words or phonemes may be mispronounced but this causes only occasional lack of clarity.*
- *Can generally be understood throughout without much effort.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- **Sound mostly natural**, but there are clear weaknesses in their pronunciation control.
- Use **intonation, rhythm, and stress** more effectively than Band 5, but they **don't sustain it** over longer turns.
- Make **occasional pronunciation mistakes**, but these **rarely confuse the listener**.
- May speak **too quickly**, or not apply correct **stress-timing**, which can hurt their rhythm.

Category	Description
Phonological features	Wide range used — stress, intonation, linking, etc. — but not always correct.
Chunking & Rhythm	Usually good, but may be rushed or uneven.
Stress & Intonation	More accurate than Band 5, but not fully reliable.
Word/Phoneme Clarity	Some errors still, especially in longer words or under pressure.
Intelligibility	Clear most of the time. Listeners can follow without much effort.

What might this sound like?

For example:

> *Let's take the sentence:*
>
> > *"I usually go shopping with my friends on weekends."*
>
> *They might sound like:*
>
> > *"I usually go shopping with my friends on weekends."*

- *Rhythm is mostly natural*
- *Stress falls correctly on "shopping," "friends," and "weekends"*
- *Might have occasional slips, like "shop-ING" instead of "SHOP-ping"*

Band 7

- *Displays some features of Band 6, and some, but not all, of the positive features of Band 8.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- Use **intonation, rhythm, and stress** quite well — especially in familiar topics.
- Can sustain **natural-sounding speech** with **few mispronunciations**.
- Still have **some slips**, especially in longer turns or with more complex ideas.
- May have an **accent**, but it doesn't make it hard to understand them.

Category	Description
Phonological Features	A good range (e.g., intonation, sentence stress, linking sounds) is used and generally controlled.
Rhythm & Chunking	Usually natural, with appropriate pauses and grouping of ideas.
Stress & Intonation	Mostly well-placed and supports meaning.
Mispronunciation	Rare, and when present, doesn't confuse the listener.
Accent	Present, but **does not interfere with understanding**.
Intelligibility	Can be easily understood throughout with no real effort from the listener.

What might this sound like?

For example:

> *Let's take the sentence:*
>
> > *"I think it's important for people to take regular breaks from work to avoid burnout."*
>
> *They might say:*
>
> > *"I think it's important for people to take regular breaks from work to avoid burnout."*

- *Proper chunking*
- *Stress on content words*
- *Intonation helps communicate attitude/opinion*
- *Maybe a slight issue with one pronunciation (e.g., "burnout" as "burn-owt"), but not distracting*

Band 8

- *Uses a wide range of phonological features to convey precise and/or subtle meaning.*
- *Can sustain appropriate rhythm. Flexible use of stress and intonation across long utterances, despite occasional lapses.*
- *Can be easily understood throughout.*
- *Accent has minimal effect on intelligibility.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- Use **stress and intonation flexibly** to make their speech **more expressive and meaningful**.
- Can **speak fluently and clearly** over **long stretches of speech**.
- Rarely make mistakes in pronunciation.
- Still have an accent, but it's **very light and doesn't interfere** at all with understanding.

Category	Description
Phonological Features	**Wide and flexible use** — they control how they sound to guide the listener.
Rhythm & Chunking	Smooth and natural even in long responses.
Stress & Intonation	Helps convey opinions, emotions, contrasts, etc.
Mispronunciation	**Very rare**. May happen occasionally but has **no impact** on listener.
Accent	Slight, **never interferes** with communication.
Intelligibility	**Effortless to understand**, even over long answers.

What might this sound like?

For example:

> *Let's take the sentence:*
>
> > *"I think it's important for people to take regular breaks from work to avoid burnout."*
>
> *They might say:*
>
> > *"I think it's important for people to take regular breaks from work, to avoid burnout."*
> > *(Spoken with expressive intonation — maybe a slight rising pitch on "important" and falling on "burnout.")*

- *Sounds natural*
- *Expresses subtle emphasis or contrast*
- *No mispronunciations*
- *Very little foreign accent*

Band 9

- *Uses a full range of phonological features to convey precise and/or subtle meaning.*
- *Flexible use of features of connected speech is sustained throughout.*
- *Can be effortlessly understood throughout.*
- *Accent has no effect on intelligibility.*

What does this mean in simple terms?

- They don't just pronounce words correctly — they use **stress**, **intonation**, **rhythm**, and **connected speech** with **complete control** to:
  - Emphasize key ideas,
  - Show emotion or contrast,
  - Maintain listener interest, and
  - Speak with **total clarity** and **fluency**.
- Their pronunciation is so good that **nothing distracts the listener**. Any **accent is either undetectable or has zero impact** on how easy they are to understand.

Category	Description
Phonological Features	Mastery of intonation, stress, pitch, and pausing. Can shift pitch to show contrast (“*I said SHE took it, not HE*”).
Connected Speech	Sounds blend naturally: linking (e.g., “go on” = /goʊ‿ɒn/), elision (e.g., “friendship” = /frɛnʃɪp/), assimilation (e.g., “good boy” = /gʊb bɔɪ/).
Rhythm	Speaks in natural, stress-timed patterns — unstressed words are reduced (“I’m going to” becomes “I’m gonna”).
Intonation	Controls pitch to show emotion, certainty, doubt, sarcasm, excitement, etc.
Accent	No impact on communication at all — very minimal, neutral, or native-sounding.
Intelligibility	Completely easy to understand from beginning to end, even in complex or lengthy responses.

What might this sound like?

For example:

> *Let’s take the sentence*:
>
> > *“Although I agree with the idea in principle, I don’t think it’s practical in the real world.”*

- **Band 9 delivery** would include:
  - Stress on contrastive elements: “I **agree** in principle, but I don’t think it’s **practical** in the real world.”
  - Smooth linking: “I-don’t-think-it’s”, “in-the-real-world”
  - Natural reductions: “don’t” pronounced as /dəʊnt/ or /dʌn/ in fast speech
  - Falling intonation to mark conclusion of thought
  - Confident rhythm — no awkward pauses